



PRAYING IN THE HOLY SPIRIT



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Lesson 1

Praying in the Spirit

1. What is true prayer?

But you, beloved, building yourselves up in your most holy faith and praying in the Holy Spirit, keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ that leads to eternal life. **Jude 1:20-21 ESV**

Praying in tongues is a form of praying in the Spirit.

True prayer in the Spirit begins in the union of the Holy Spirit. To pray in the Spirit is to pray “in Him” as a person. When you pray in the Spirit, you are aligning yourself to Him.

2. It's possible to pray in the flesh.

Now may the God of peace himself sanctify you completely and may your whole spirit and soul and body be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.

1 Thessalonians 5:23 NKJV

When you pray, you are either praying in the soul, spirit, or flesh. When we pray, our goal is to establish a spiritual connection.

To pray from the Spirit is to pray from that place of union with God.

But he who is joined to the Lord is one spirit with Him. **1 Corinthians 6:17 NKJV**

Prayer is often viewed as work instead of fellowship. Don't pray to connect with God; pray from a connection with God.

Lesson 2

What is the Gift of Tongues?

But it was to us that God revealed these things by his Spirit. For his Spirit searches out everything and shows us God's deep secrets. **1 Corinthians 2:10 NLT**

The Scripture tells us that the Holy Spirit searches the depths of God. He understands every detail of God. Then, He takes what He knows about the Father and communicates it with us.

1. The Holy Spirit helps us in our weakness.

And the Holy Spirit helps us in our weakness. For example, we don't know what God wants us to pray for. But the Holy Spirit prays for us with groanings that cannot be expressed in words.

Romans 8:26 NLT

The Holy Spirit is one with you and has a fellowship with the Father and a fellowship with you. So, in the spirit, you already know God; you are already complete.

Spiritual growth isn't your spirit growing. It's when the rest of you catches up to who you are.

Understanding this completeness and union will help you understand the gift of tongues.

2. The Holy Spirit prays for us in our weakness.

Romans 8:26 tells us that the Holy Spirit prays for you. He prays with us with groanings: power, force, and might.

He pulls you in to align you to the will of the Father. We participate with the Holy Spirit when we obey. Your spirit and the Holy Spirit are one.

"For if I pray in tongues, my spirit is praying..." **1 Corinthians 14:14 NLT**

When you pray in tongues, out of the union with the Holy Spirit, you allow the Holy Spirit to pray for you and through you. And that which the Holy Spirit prays in the spiritual realm, manifests. You are the body of the Holy Spirit.

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Lesson 2 Continued

3. What happens when you pray in tongues?

When you pray in tongues, you allow Him to have a voice through you.

What is strengthened when you speak in tongues?

- The intensification in the gifts
- The ability to hear the voice of God
- The ability to love more
- The ability to read the Word

Lesson 3

The Gift of Tongues

There are three expressions of the gift of tongues:

- **Personal**
- **Proof**
- **Prophetic**

1. Personal

Let love be your highest goal! But you should also desire the special abilities the Spirit gives — especially the ability to prophesy. For if you have the ability to speak in tongues, you will be talking only to God, since people won't be able to understand you. You will be speaking by the power of the Spirit, but it will all be mysterious. But one who prophesies strengthens others, encourages them, and comforts them. A person who speaks in tongues is strengthened personally, but one who speaks a word of prophecy strengthens the entire church. **1 Corinthians 14:1-4 NLT**

Paul is not criticizing the gift of tongues; he says prophecy is better because it edifies the Church.

This expression of tongues shows that your self is the one being edified. It requires no interpretation for the benefit of the individual. It is understood by none but God.

2. Proof

And everyone present was filled with the Holy Spirit and began speaking in other languages,[a] as the Holy Spirit gave them this ability. At that time there were devout Jews from every nation living in Jerusalem. When they heard the loud noise, everyone came running, and they were bewildered to hear their own languages being spoken by the believers. **Acts 2:4-6 NLT**

In this verse, the Holy Spirit supernaturally interpreted the tongues so everyone could hear and understand them. These were not interpreted by anyone, but supernaturally understood by the unbeliever.

The second expression of the gift is spoken as tongues but heard as a language.

It requires no interpreter for the unbeliever to be benefited.

Lesson 3 Continued

3. Prophetic

Well, my brothers and sisters, let's summarize. When you meet together, one will sing, another will teach, another will tell some special revelation God has given, one will speak in tongues, and another will interpret what is said. But everything that is done must strengthen all of you. No more than two or three should speak in tongues. They must speak one at a time, and someone must interpret what they say. But if no one is present who can interpret, they must be silent in your church meeting and speak in tongues to God privately. **1 Corinthians 14:26-28 NLT**

This gift commands the attention of the whole congregation. This edifies the body as a whole; It is usually in churches or wherever the Body of Christ is united.

Paul placed a restriction on this gift in this context so that one gift would not take over the whole service.

It is an expression understood by the entire audience as a language.

The gift of tongues can benefit the believer, the unbeliever, and the whole Body of Christ.

4. The Benefits

1. Personal expression: benefits the individual
2. Proof expression: benefits the unbeliever
3. Prophetic expression: benefits the Church

Lesson 4

8 Myths About Tongues, Part 1

Myth 1: Paul discouraged believers from praying in tongues.

Let love be your highest goal! But you should also desire the special abilities the Spirit gives—especially the ability to prophesy. For if you have the ability to speak in tongues, you will be talking only to God, since people won't be able to understand you. You will be speaking by the power of the Spirit, but it will all be mysterious. But one who prophesies strengthens others, encourages them, and comforts them. A person who speaks in tongues is strengthened personally, but one who speaks a word of prophecy strengthens the entire church. **1 Corinthians 14:1-4 NLT**

The Truth:

People think that Paul is condemning the gift of tongues, but on the contrary, he is comparing the gifts and showing his favoritism to the edification of the Body of Christ when an opportunity arises for that expression.

When gathered, the usage of the gift for the edification of the Body is more favorable over the expression of self-edification.

Paul was not saying that speaking in tongues has no purpose, but prophecy has a greater purpose in the church setting.

He encourages it in verse 5:

I wish you could all speak in tongues, but even more I wish you could all prophesy. For prophecy is greater than speaking in tongues, unless someone interprets what you are saying so that the whole church will be strengthened. **1 Corinthians 14:5 NLT**

Lesson 4 Continued

Myth 2: Praying in tongues should not be practiced in public or group settings.

The Truth:

Dear brothers and sisters, if I should come to you speaking in an unknown language, how would that help you? But if I bring you a revelation or some special knowledge or prophecy or teaching, that will be helpful. But in a church meeting I would rather speak five understandable words to help others than ten thousand words in an unknown language.

1 Corinthians 14:6, 19 NLT

Paul is specifically addressing the prevention of the disruption of church services. He was not outlawing the gift of tongues but instead bringing order to church services.

Well, my brothers and sisters, let's summarize. When you meet together, one will sing, another will teach, another will tell some special revelation God has given, one will speak in tongues, and another will interpret what is said. But everything that is done must strengthen all of you. **1 Corinthians 14:26 NLT**

This does not mean you shouldn't pray in tongues collectively or publicly. However, if the gift is disrupting the flow of the service, interpretation is required.

Examples of the Gift with No Interpretation

The Bible shows examples where the church prayed collectively, and no interpretations were required:

1. They all spoke in tongues. "And everyone present was filled with the Holy Spirit and began speaking in other languages, as the Holy Spirit gave them this ability."

Acts 2:4 NLT

2. They all spoke in tongues. "Then when Paul laid his hands on them, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they spoke in other tongues and prophesied." **Acts 19:6 NLT**

3. "So you see that speaking in tongues is a sign, not for believers, but for unbelievers. Prophecy, however, is for the benefit of believers, not unbelievers."

1 Corinthians 14:22 NLT

Why would the Holy Spirit pour out the gift in a public setting if it was only meant for private use? The fact that the Holy Spirit pours out His Spirit in public is evidence that it should be used publicly.

Lesson 4 Continued

How is it supposed to be a sign for unbelievers if it's hidden in private? These examples show us how they were collectively, without an interpreter, speaking in tongues and the Holy Spirit gave them power.

He would not do that if this were against His will.

Myth 3: Tongues are not heavenly, only earthly languages.

For if you have the ability to speak in tongues, you will be talking only to God, since people won't be able to understand you. You will be speaking by the power of the Spirit, but it will all be mysterious.

1 Corinthians 14:2 NLT

A person who speaks in tongues is strengthened personally, but one who speaks a word of prophecy strengthens the entire church.

1 Corinthians 14:4 NLT

The Truth:

We see in Scripture that it is very clearly a heavenly language that man cannot understand.

What about Acts 2:6?

"Now when this was noised abroad, the multitude came together, and were confounded, because that every man heard them speak in his own language." KJV

Each member of the onlookers in this verse heard the collective of the believers praying in their own language.

How could they be praying in an individual language all at once?

This leads to the conclusion that each onlooker heard the whole group of believers praying in their own language. It wasn't necessarily that they were speaking earthly languages. Rather the individuals supernaturally heard the believers speaking in their own language.

Lesson 4 Continued

Myth 4: This gift is not for every Believer.

Are we all apostles? Are we all prophets? Are we all teachers? Do we all have the power to do miracles? Do we all have the gift of healing? Do we all have the ability to speak in unknown languages? Do we all have the ability to interpret unknown languages? Of course not! So you should earnestly desire the most helpful gifts. But now let me show you a way of life that is best of all. **1 Corinthians 12:29-31 NLT**

The Truth:

Notice that these are all public expressions of ministry. Paul is not addressing the personal prayer language, but the public gift used with the gift of interpretation. Paul is not talking about the private expression but the public expression.

“A spiritual gift is given to each of us so we can help each other.” **1 Corinthians 12:7 NLT**

All the gifts listed in chapter 12 benefit someone else. As a result, Paul could not be talking about the personal expression of tongues because all the other gifts mentioned in this chapter are used to benefit others.

All the other gifts listed are “others” focused, not “self” focused.

Imagine if we used this same logic for all other gifts listed that we do on the gift of tongues—Do all have gifts of healing? If not, then healing does not belong to them?

A person who speaks in tongues is strengthened personally, but one who speaks a word of prophecy strengthens the entire church. I wish you could all speak in tongues, but even more I wish you could all prophesy. For prophecy is greater than speaking in tongues, unless someone interprets what you are saying so that the whole church will be strengthened. **1 Corinthians 14:4-5 NLT**

Not every believer has the gift of interpretation of tongues for public use, but the private expression is for everyone.

Lesson 5

8 Myths About Tongues, Part 2

Myth 5: Spiritual gifts are no longer in operation.

The Truth:

Cessationism deals with extra-Biblical claim that states the gifts have ceased to operate in our day and age. However, generally speaking, Biblical evidence is overwhelming for the continual operation of the spiritual gifts.

Cessationists use speculation, arguments from history, and semantics to disprove the operation of the gifts of the Holy Spirit today.

However, there is not a single verse that supports the cessationist position. The spiritual gifts are still alive today, just as they were in the apostles' day and age.

Myth 6: Jesus didn't speak in tongues, so we shouldn't either.

The Truth:

Just because Jesus didn't pray in tongues does not mean we shouldn't. Praying in tongues supplements our inability to pray, and it's used to help us when we don't know what to pray.

Jesus didn't need to pray in tongues because He was perfect.

Myth 7: You can become demonized if you try to speak in tongues.

"You fathers—if your children ask for a fish, do you give them a snake instead? Or if they ask for an egg, do you give them a scorpion? Of course not! So if you sinful people know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him." **Luke 11:11-13 NLT**

Lesson 5 Continued

The Truth:

Snakes and scorpions were symbolic of demonic beings. This text shows us that it's not possible to get demons when you're asking the Father for the Holy Spirit. It's not in His nature to do that.

Our trust should not be in our ability to receive but in His ability to give.

Myth 8: You can't control the gift.

The Truth:

The belief that the gift can't be controlled prevents people from receiving it.

Chapter 14 of 1st Corinthians lays out a protocol on how to control this gift.

Why would God give us a gift if the gift could not be controlled?

All gifts require an exercise of faith on the part of the one using them. This gift is not any different.

Lesson 6

How to Activate the Gift

Wherefore I put thee in remembrance that thou stir up the gift of God, which is in thee by the putting on of my hands. **2 Timothy 1:6 KJV**

Spiritual gifts cannot be taught in a literal sense.

When we say, “learn how to pray in tongues,” the truth is that only the Holy Spirit can cause these operations to activate in your life.

But every believer can “activate” the gift.

You can choose to stir up the personal gift in your life. Although the gift itself cannot be taught, what can be taught is to surrender to the Holy Spirit so that He can activate it within you.

When you pray in tongues, you are speaking syllables and sounds void of your intention and meaning, and you’re allowing Him to attach His intentions and His meaning.

“Why can’t I talk in tongues?”

Ego is why most people can’t pray in tongues. They are too concerned with themselves.

Common Obstacles:

1. Pride – “I’ll look weird.”
2. Fear – “What if it’s just me?”
3. We wait for the Holy Spirit to do it all - not understanding it’s a partnership.

Speaking in tongues is surrendering your speech to the Holy Spirit. Surrender those syllables and sounds and they will flow.